from Bihar's Saran district, who sailed from Calcutta to the Caribbean in 1903 as a 'coolie', pregnant and alone, to work on a sugar plantation in British Guiana.[9]

Along with indenture contracts, the Indians took with them the world of the Ramayana, and the flavours and spices of the Indian subcontinent.[10] Outside the sugar plantations, the Indians began to cultivate rice on their own lands. They resisted the brutalities of the plantation world by organizing strikes on the sugar plantations in the early 20th century. From the 1940s, when malaria was brought under control in Guyana, Indians witnessed a demographic, economic and political upsurge as they moved away from the plantations. Faced with common adversaries far away from home, the caste system began to disappear as identities were reshaped along racial lines.[11] People of Indian origin now make up around 40 per cent of the Guyanese population, similar to those who trace their origins to Africa. It is tensions between these two groups that defined politics before and after Independence in 1966. If India has been an important part of the Guyanese imagination, Guyana entered cricketing folklore in India through Clive Lloyd, one of the most successful captains of the stylish and dominant West Indies cricket team of the 1970s, and two brilliant cricketers of Indo-Guyanese heritage: Rohan Kanhai and Shivnarine Chanderpaul.

A few hundred kilometres off the coast of Guyana are the islands of Trinidad and Tobago, the birthplace of Nobel Laureate V.S. Naipaul, whose writings were a hallmark of 20th century literature. His grandparents had moved from a place near Gorakhpur, a key north Indian centre in the Great Indian Migration Wave, to Trinidad in 1894 aboard a ship called the *Hereford* and indentured as coolies at Woodford Lodge estate.[12] But Naipaul was not among the first emigrants as indentured migration to Trinidad had begun four decades earlier. Between 1845 and 1917, around 1,50,000 indentured labourers were shipped to the plantations of Trinidad, sharing similar characteristics with the emigrants to Guyana.[13] Less than a quarter of them returned to India. On arrival after a long sea journey, the workers were lodged at Nelson Island for a medical examination. Then they spent a few days or weeks at a local depot before heading for the plantations. In